



The Personal Statement



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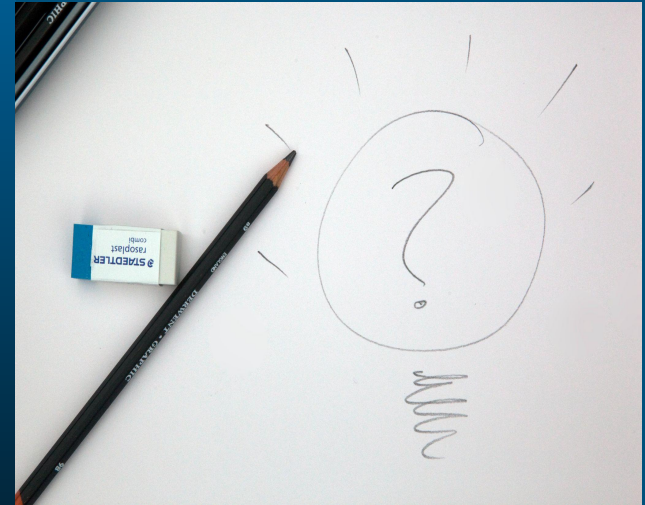
OBJECTIVES:

- ★ Look at why the personal essay is important and why colleges ask for it
- ★ Cover the kind/types of essay questions that answer to the personal statement.
- ★ Discuss what sets apart great and successful essays from the rest.
- ★ Cover important tips and tricks that you should use in your essay writing.
- ★ Look at some examples of impressive common app essays.



What is the Personal Statement?

- ★ The Personal Statement : this is a unique essay that you write about yourself. Think of it as the metaphorical heart of your application.
- ★ It is meant to capture your 'Human nature' and more specifically certain events in your life that brought out the same about you.
- ★ A personal statement should be a mirror reflecting your:
 1. Vulnerability and how you have /plan to overcome them
 2. Skills- these can be cognitive or non-cognitive skills
 3. Passions- your desires and interests
 4. Values- virtues and traits that build your personality



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

1.Introspection/ Self reflection

- ★ This involves brainstorming a unique topic that will separate you from the 50,000 applicants you will be competing with
- ★ Always have your PS in mind
- ★ Make sure your train of thought travels along the rails of:
 1. Is my topic emotional?
 2. Is my topic authentic?
 3. Is my topic distinct or above normal expectations?



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ You have to see yourself through your inner lenses
- ★ Ask yourself what makes you human
- ★ Close your eyes, take a deep breath, and think about you and only you
- ★ Think of those key events that bring/has brought out the human in you
- ★ You might find yourself stirring the worst of your past emotions



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

2. Write your ideas down

- ★ Jot down the topics you see fit as soon as they pop to mind
- ★ Start reflecting on the anecdotes that will describe the topic to full length
- ★ Anecdotes bring your ideas to life. They give a personal touch to whatever you are trying to narrate
- ★ If your essay is vulnerable, you should have an anecdote(s) that show(s) how you overcame the same



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

3. Choosing a prompt

- ★ With the ideas in place, you can start thinking on which prompt to answer in the Common App



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

The following are last year prompts that you may start accommodating your ideas.

- ★ Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.
- ★ The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?
- ★ Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

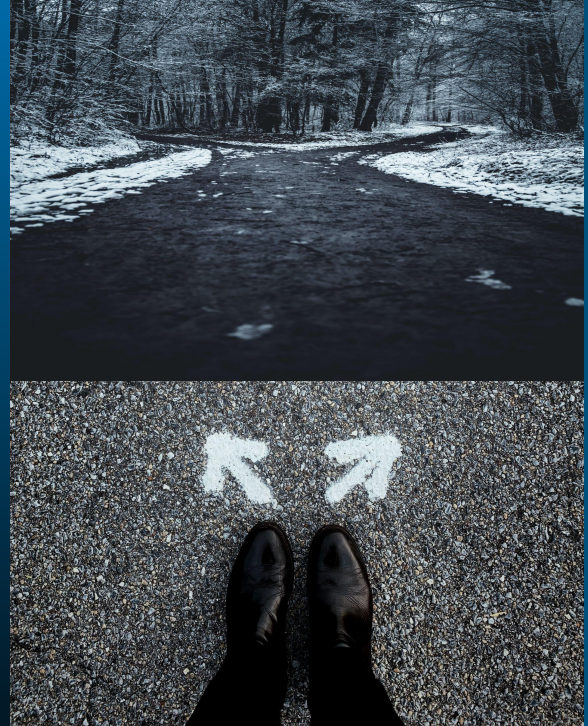
- ★ Reflect on something that someone has done for you that has made you happy or thankful in a surprising way. How has this gratitude affected or motivated you?
- ★ Discuss an accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked a period of personal growth and a new understanding of yourself or others.



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ Describe a topic, idea, or concept you find so engaging that it makes you lose all track of time. Why does it captivate you? What or who do you turn to when you want to learn more?
- ★ Share an essay on any topic of your choice. It can be one you've already written, one that responds to a different prompt, or one of your own design.

Take time to choose a prompt that can cover all parts of your personality that you would want to exploit(multifaceted response). How you answer a certain question can either give you an inch over or under your opponent.



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

4. Weaving your ideas into the essay

These can take two forms

- Narrative form
- Montage form

The Narrative essay

- ★ This involves narrating your story in a prose culmination of events. An event leads to another which sequentially escalates the narrative to a climax.
- ★ This is common for vulnerable essays with suitable anecdotes in play.
- ★ Your essay can begin with a third person point of view to enchant the reader(s).

STEPS TO WRITE YOUR PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ Your narrative should portray a continuous flow of ideas with no paragraph deflecting from the main plot
- ★ Your narrative should explore styles of vivid description, self expression, organization and uniqueness. You want the AO to have a complete knowledge of who you are.
- ★ The greatest way you can have a connection with the reader is to establish an emotional stand. Keeping in mind that what affects the heart affects the mind more.



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ Your essay should have four parts:
 - Status Quo
 - Incident that changes the status quo
 - Raise of stakes to the climax
 - Moment of truth
 - Outcome



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

An example of a good [personal narrative](#). You can also find another [here](#)



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

Montage Essay

- ★ Montage a technique that involves using separate elements (pictures, words, music, etc.) to create a new whole. A montage essay is an essay usually exploring different aspects of yourself by alluding to essence objects.
- ★ Essence objects are one that you can identify with. One that you can allude to different parts of your identity, values or traits
- ★ You can use different objects to talk about yourself. But what will weave them together is your theme.
- ★ Think of this as an unsolved Rubiks cube. But with good craft you can make the essay a common block of ideas.



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ Finding a Thematic Thread → If you're going to build a montage, you need to find a way to make the different experiences you'll use feel connected. Think of it this way: if I just had a paragraph on growing up in Latin America, speaking of which religion, speaking of which literature is important to me, speaking of which... you're going to feel understandably confused.
- ★ So I need to have something that threads the pieces together. The sample essay below ("Laptop Stickers") was written by a student who collected stickers on her laptop. Each sticker connected to different values and experiences. Stickers are her thematic thread.

Examples: [A Laptop Montage essay](#) and [A Dance Montage essay](#).

More about both essays can be found [here](#). Check out other resources [here](#), [here](#) and [here](#)



STEPS TO WRITE A PERSONAL STATEMENT

- ★ 5. Write your first of many drafts.
- ★ 6. Revising the essay.
- ★ 7. Draft again. Revise. Repeat.



WHY IS A PS IMPORTANT?

- ★ Showcases your writing ability(A good indication of academic prowess besides grades and SAT)
- ★ It's the window through which admission officers get insight into your personality.
- ★ It is the one part that you have control over and can be used as a way to promote yourself.
- ★ Can be used to distinguish students who have similar academic qualifications.

Basically, the essay(s) bring(s) the your application to life. Admissions

officers are able to have put a person behind all the numbers, ranks and achievements shown in the rest of the application.



WHAT MAKES A PS SUCCESSFUL?

- ★ You can identify the applicant's core values- you can clearly see the applicant's motivation and sense of fulfilment i.e hard work, perseverance, or determination
- ★ It is vulnerable - the more an applicants opens up, the more the reader feels closer to the writer. This has an effect of making the applicant memorable
- ★ It shows insight and growth- an applicant's response to adversities is clearly brought out
- ★ It is crafty- the essay is eloquently written, has vivid description and self expression, has a stream of flow, and has unique writing styles



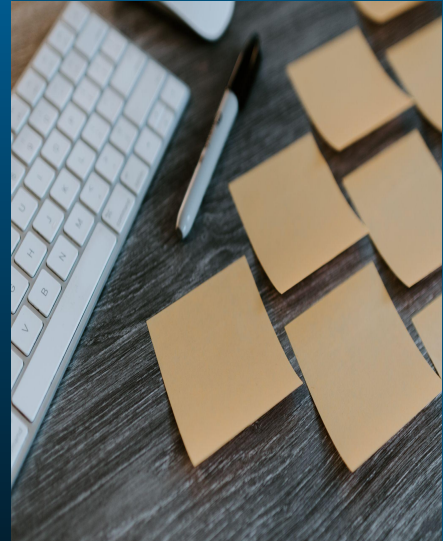
WHAT MAKES A PS SUCCESSFUL

- ★ It perfectly aligns with other parts of the application
- ★ It is not redundant- should focus on the areas not mentioned on other parts of the application
- ★ It is creative- should show the applicant's level of rational thought in his writing as well as in his expression of ideas
- ★ It is authentic



AWESOME TRICKS TO USE

- ★ Start your essay writing process early! Be ahead of the game!
- ★ Pick a topic that you are genuinely excited about.
- ★ Be as specific as you can. Avoid vague and generic ideas and descriptions.
- ★ Use your own voice.
- ★ Show, don't tell!
- ★ Allow your friends and advisors to read your essay in order to gain an objective opinion.
- ★ Write at least 6 drafts. Have fun as you engage with them
- ★ Read your essay carefully and objectively, constantly edit and work on ways that you can improve it.



BE AHEAD OF THE GAME





ANY QUESTION?



ASK AWAY !





ALL THE BEST IN YOUR ESSAY JOURNEY!